PETITION TO THE POLITICAL DEPARTMENT
OF THE
SWISS FEDERAL GOVERNMENT. BERN.

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At the outbreak of the War in 1914 I was engaged by the Russian Holy Synod under contract to undertake the purchase of Beeswax, Oils and Incense throughout the whole world.

Before the war, the supplies of the above named articles used to come almost entirely from Germany, in which country on the outbreak of war there were still considerable quantities in stock. It was my task to get these into Russia by any possible means, because the Synod was depending on the delivery of these parcels. During my first trip for the purpose of organising wax purchases, I went through Germany without, however, being able to buy up the parcels lying there. I then chose London as the headquarters for my purchases and soon succeeded in collecting there the whole wax supplies of the world, and I appointed buying agents for each quarter of the globe. Through thus monopolising the article, 95% of which was absorbed by the Russian Church, I was able to regulate prices and secure low price wax for the Church, while at the same time, the Wax producers had a good profit, as all former profits of dealers, and war speculation - which had become a fashion - were done away with. Thanks to the energy of my collaborators and the very active help and assistance on the part of the British Government (The Home Office and various Chambers of Commerce), who were glad enough on gaining an insight into the business to find that this important trade - which up to then had been entirely in German hands - was to be concentrated in London, the business grew in the first year to such an extent as to satisfy the Holy Synod. On the other hand, the greatest possible anger and rage on the part of the dealers whose services were dispensed with were raised against my person, and I was exposed to the greatest possible intrigues and threats as a consequence of which I obtained the protection of the Russian Minister of Justice.

As long as there was any possibility of transporting the goods via London into Russia, the whole requirements of the Russian Church were fully covered, but afterwards when it became impossible to trans-

port any goods other than those intended for war purposes, and when moreover, the rouble exchange rose to such a height as to render foreign business practically impossible, the Holy Synod decided, for the time being, to use substitutes in the place of pure Beeswax. As Russia had to import even the substitutes, with the exception of Ozokerite which was obtained in small quantities in the Naptha region of Baku, the Synod decided to entrust me with the solution of the Ozokerite question, and to enter if possible upon the exploitation of this product. I tried to extract Ozokerite from the Bitumen which existed in the neighbourhood of the Black Sea, but my experiments failed owing to the low percentage of Ceresine in the above named raw product, whereupon I went to the Island of Chelekem in the Caspian Sea, where experts had found Oxokerite in sufficient quantities. The quality was lower than that of the Galician Ozokerite but could be brought by chemical treatment up to the desired level.

By December 1917, the preliminary negotiations for the purchase of Ozokerite mines on the Island of Cheleken (and some of it in different parts of the Island from natives and smaller prospectors) were concluded, and contracts were made with suitable engineers, chemists and workmen. I then went to Petrograd in order to submit my project to the Holy Synod, and to settle up everything, including the financial question.

At the end of March, I returned to Baku, the business then assumed definite lines, the purchasing contract with Isabeck Gadjinsky was signed, chemical works at Astrachan (Elidaroff) were leased with the option of purchasing same at a later period, at the same time a contract was made with the Russo-Caucasian Co. at Baku for the purification of the crude Ozokerite at their works. Crude Ozokerite was bought, received and purified and all necessary agreements for the proper working of the business were made. The political situation presented certain difficulties and I therefore telegraphed to the Synod asking them to send someone with full authority to act and to assist me whenever necessary.

As Deputy of the Synod then appeared Protchierei (Russian word for a head-priest) Vadoff, and he conducted negotiations with the Bolshevik Government, until the Government in Transcaspia fell into the hands of the Menshevik. Cheleken was declared to belong to

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the Memshevik Government, and we therefore decided to go to Kradnavosk, (Krasnovodsk?) with the priest Vadoff in order to discuss and put right our Cheleken business with the new Government. Besides, I had bought a parcel of crude Ozokerite in Krasnovodsk, the Bill of Lading for which was in my hands, yet the goods had not been sent off to Baku as the signature of the new Government became necessary. The Engineer, W.Schmidt who had been recently engaged by me accompanied us to Krasnovodsk, as he is a specialist in Cheleken Ozokerite, and had taken charge of the whole exploitation of the Gadjinsky Ozokerite Works. On arrival at Krasnovodsk, we had an interview with the representative of the new government - Mr. Wm. Heinrichowitsch Kuhn, and as he wanted to have some information regarding my sentiments, the Priest Vadoff gave a full explanation in writing, and he added that I had full power to act in all matters affecting the department in question of the Holy Synod; moreover he wired to Petrograd asking the Synod to confirm to Mr. Kuhn the declaration which he had made. It turned out that the signature on the Bill of Lading could only be given at Askabad. I therefore went to Askabad with Mr. Schmidt - whereas the Priest Vadoff left for Astrachan in order to wait for me there.

It was my first visit to Askabad, and I knew nobody there, whereas Schmidt was well-known and had friends amongst all classes, as he had occupied at different times official positions in Turkestan. The negotiations with the government were commenced immediately and the business aroused considerable interest. We arrived at Askabad on August 2nd. and on August 4th the details were to be discussed with the Government. However, it did not come to this, as Mr. Schmidt was declard to be a prisoner and I had to give a written undertaking not to leave Askabad. We were brought before the examining magistrate and then taken into an hotel with escort - our belongings and papers were examined, and Mr. Lenski, a lawyer, examined all my documents and other papers carefully, and as he could not find anything compromising in them, he made his apologies and went away after informing us that we were free and that in the evening our negotiations with the government, which had been interrupted, would be continued.

At 6 p.m. we were again in the Government offices, and waited

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a whole hour for their representatives, and at last were taken by a gentleman to the Commandant of the town, and entered a hall in which there were four gentleman, surrounded by an armed escort. After waiting for hours, a man called Makarenke came - he declared us prisoners - gave orders for us to be taken away - and disappeared without answering our questions. We were taken into the prison, our pockets were examined and our money and documents taken away from us. I had in my possession at the time 55400 Roubles, which I had to deliver up. A receipt was promised me for the following day. My question as to why we were prisoners was hot answered. On the following day, Makarenke appeared and declared the Englishmen had given orders for our arrest and that we should be handed over to them shortly. Telegrams and letters which we wanted to send off were refused. One member or our party, Dr. Wagner, succeeded in sending a messenger to Astrachan who was to inform the German Relief Committee No. 13. to which he belonged, and he was also to let the Priest Vadoff know that we were prisoners. Besides, Mr. Schmidt managed to send letters of protest to the authorities, to the newspapers and to the Polish Colony. Through Maroscff I asked the assistance of a lawyer called Dorer, but on the following day, I was informed that I should have to pay 2,000 roubles in advance, otherwise the lawyer would not come, but, as all my money had been taken away from me, I had to remain withour assistance. After having been detained in the prison for about two weeks, we were conducted at 1 o'clock in the morning under armed escort consisting of Armenian volunteers by special train to the station Artick at the Persian frontier. I asked Makarenko, who accompanied us from the prison for the last time for a receipt for the 55400 roubles, whereupon he replied that my documents and money would follow me, and if the Englishmen were to release us, which he was hoping, I should get everything back, otherwise, I should receive a receipt from the Englishmen.

At Artick, I was received by a British Officer with a strong convoy. The officer said that he was sorry but that he would have to put us into chains. When we protested, he declared that he had strict orders to that effect. Then we were tied together with ropes in batches of 5 and 4 men each, and driven across the Persian frontier. Shortly

afterwards, we were placed on two carts and after an eight hours journe we arrived at Machmedabad, where we were photographed and an officer addressed us in German. He declared that he was very glad to see us as enemies before him, but he felt sorry for us as human beings. We protested and declared that we were no enemies and that our party consisted of various nationalities including neutrals, whereupon he answered that it was quite clear that in view of our lucrative business each of us wou have to have a different passport, which made me think that we were look upon as German spies. I told him that I was a representative of the mo conservative institution in Russia, which would be sufficient to prove m sentiments, and I said that I was carrying out very lucrative work in Turkestan for the Holy Synod, which was sufficient to explain my financi position and I told him that I was inpossession of a Swiss Courier passport, which is not issued to doubtful individuals. The Officer retorte that just because I had a Courier passport which was made out for Tiflis, I was the person which they took me to be.

The Camp Commandant at Machmedabad declared that we would be handed over to a court at Meshhed. We had to take off all our clothes an pack them together - then we were given Persian peasant garments, so that there were no traces of our origin left, even the cross which the Russian Officer Lovenke had worn round his neck since his baptism was taken away away from him. This masquerade, and the signs of the Indians who put us into chains, and which permitted of no misinterpretation, put us into the greatest state of excitement : no one doubted that our hour had come. An Indian officer with 25 men, both cavalry and infantry with 25 camels and 50 mules accompanied us. The prisoners sat tied on to mules or Persian horses, held by ropes both right and left. It was a long caravan which made its way through the mountains, the Persians who hurried from the villages to see us were driven away by whip-laskes. We were informed that if we gave the least cause for it we should be shot by the Indians; it looked as if an attack or an attempt to liberate us on the part of the part of the Persians was expected. The mental excitement made us forget the bodily torments which were caused through the long ride in coarse Persian trousers on unsaddled horses, from which we were sore and bleeding We spent four nights on horseback until we arrived at Kutschan, in stages of 12-14 hours. The coolness of the night in our thin Persian garments,

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which left our chests completely exposed, kept us from fainting. The groans of the 8 prisoners could be heard above the trample of the horses. The Indian soldiers treated us most roughly, and it was impossible to make ourselves understood. Of food there was practically none, but we had not missed it very much as we were too excited. At Kutschan we were thrown on the ground one after the other and were fettered with iron fetters, two together, one strapped across the other, and our feet were tied together with ropes while the natives looked on with derisive laughter.

On the following day, a British officer called Forsit appeared, He/declared that he had strict orders but when we protested that their conduct was inhuman, he tried to mitigate our tortures as far as his orders permitted to do so, and we were grateful to this young officer. He also tried to make travelling easier for Schimdt who was a man of 58 years, yet like others he fell from his horse unconscious.

Half dead, we arrived on the 7th day at Meshhed, where we were housed in tents - two men in a tent - in the barrack square under the supervision of an officer called Uloth. Forsit had caught Pneumonia, although he wore a fur coat which he kept on during the cold nights, so that we did not see him again until two weeks after, when he was convalescent. Uloth had done his best to scoff and torture us, all our requests to speak to General Malleson or to put our business before him in writing were left unconsidered, likewise my urgent plea to be allowed to advise my brother, Dr. Stump in Teheran, Persia, that I had been taken prisoner, and to let him know where I was. Once we were cross-examined by an officer called Gordon, who took notes. I had once seen Gordon drive past the Grand Hotel, Ashabad, in a carriage with another British officer in uniform, accompanied by a Russian sailor of the Caspian fleet. Gordon declared in connection with my Courier passport that there was no Swiss Consul at all in Tiflis, nor did he believe that I had not been at Tiflis at all. Afterwards I learned that Gordon had lived at Tiflis - spoke Russian fluently - knew the contents of my six official identity documents with

under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuffed

with/ photograph, and all my contracts and correspondence in Russian, which he confiscated - so he was bound to know who I was, and what the nature of my business had been. Moreover, behind the scenes he had dealings with the new government in Ashabad, and he must have read the official declaration which the Priest Vadoff gave to Kuhn at Krasnovodsk, as Kuhn had sent on the information about me to Aschabad. Besides, I told Gordon that I had a brother at Teheran, who had been an official of the State for 15 years, and asked him to inform my brother that I was a prisoner, as my brother in his position could have cleard up the whole matter at once, and would have stood security for me in every respect. Gordon declared that he knew nothing about the 55400 roubles, which had been taken from me, but he was going to make enquiries. After spending a fortnight under awful treatment on the part of Uloth, we were taken into the mountains. By that time, all of us had dysentery through eating dogs meat, which was poured from dirty vessls into our hands by filthy natives, as we had neither forks, spoons, knives or plates at our disposal. Later on, I received from a native who took pity on me, a plate which at one time must have been enamelled, and from which, until that time, the fox terrier belonging to an officer took his food. We were not allowed to speak to any of the natives who acted as our guards, which in any case would be impossible, as they only spoke Indian. Only once a farrier brought us soup. He spoke English and I seized the opportunity of asking him what would happen to us, upon which he replied that probably we would be "destroyed" like others before us - excepting those who had managed to escape. The farrier did not come back, because it had been noticed that I had spoken to him. A superior officer came to see us, and asked "Are you all right?" We clung to him and begged for a "Fair trial" as was usual amongst Englishmen; he promised much but did not return. We were then sent on, after having been cross-examined by Uloth and Gordon. Up to that time only our papers had been taken from us, now all our belongings were taken, my clothes - linen - all of which came from London, my new kitbag, leather suit case, etc; my tie-pin a beautiful pearl was taken by Mr. Uloth. Mr. Gordon took my purse under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuff

purse/ containing small change, photographs of my children, and heavy gold cuff links which had been presented to me by an Englishman; my portfolio with gold penholder and other small articles of value. The sole satisfaction that was left to me was to hear Uloth say to Gordon "This chap has rather good things". I was not allowed to put on my pigskin leggings, so I had to continue the journey with bare legs - the persian sandals were worn through and small pebbles were collecting in them - it was like walking on peas. We received old horse blankets and were marched into the mountains where tents were pitched. There were eight pits, one beside the other, and one did not need to be very farsighted to see that these were intended for the eight of us. Immediately after our arrival a long line of 60 Austrians and Hungarians arrived, chained together in fives. Dr. Wagner recognised them as prisoners of war, who had passed four years in captivity in Russia, and who latterly had earned good money through working at Ashabad. Besides these there were two men from our Aschabad prison, also a rich local Persian, an Indian from Meshhed, and a tall stately looking man, who afterwards proved to be Dr. Rendorff, secretary to the Danish Legation at Petrograd.

We were received by an officer called Thompson and the 72 of us had to stand to attention. Thompson asked who amongst us could speak English, and when I said that I could, he took me to his side and told me that he wanted to appoint me as captain of the camp, and I was to take over charge of the kitchen and the whole practical management of the camp, and to be responsible for same. In exchange for this, my fetters were to be removed from me while cooking went on, but my work was not of long duration. Uloth appeared and declared that I was the greatest criminal and that my chains must not be taken from me; scoffing and laughing he left me. We were placed three in a tent, and under penalty of death were forbidden to converse with anyone in another tent. I had the responsibility for my tent, and was to be shot like a dog if anyone spoke to anybody in another tent. The Russian escort who had brought the 60 men from Turkestan to us were put in chains and treated similarly as prisoners. The four weeks on the mountains were extremely torturous, all of us had dysentery to a high degree under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuff

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and were practically eaten up by lice, as we could not wash nor had any clothes to change. At night we were chained five men together and in addition to that tied with ropes, so that our blood circulation stopped and it was only just possible to lie stretched out on our backs. Owing to the awful dysentery, every now and again one of the five men chained together had to go out, and of course the four remaining ones had to follow each time, groaning and swaying to the latrine pit and all the time being scoffed and jeered at by the natives. So we lay, on our backs, curling ourselves with pain and eaten up with vermin until the next one had to go out. An Army doctor of high degree appeared, and as the famous pill box (opium) was no longer of any use, the doctor ordered a complete change of diet. Thompson called me and promised improvement in the diet, and I took the opportunity of pointing out to him that the cruel tying-up during the night was quite useless as we were already chained together with iron fetters, which was quite sufficient. Moreover, each tent has several guards. A machine gun was placed in position to cover the whole camp and 50 soldiers both cavalry and infantry had their quarters in the camp. The food did not improve, but we were no longer roped together, for which I earned the thanks of my fellow-sufferers.

The Austrians and Hungarians were made prisoners two weeks after us at Aschabad. It appeared that when they heard that the Swedish delegates, Messrs. Mourin and Wagner, and the other members of our party were taken prisoners they sent a deputation to the Aschabad government asking for our immediate release, as we were perfectly innocent. The Turkish prison guard at Aschabad also refused to carry out their duties for the same reason and their places were taken by armed railway employees - the 60 Austrian-Hungarians were made prisoners, put into chains and sent into Persia - more then 60 men were thus taken, but the majority were allowed their freedom again, and in two cases one went in the place of another, which shows that they did not want to make certain persons prisoners but they had to bring in a certain number of prisoners, for whom the Englishmen had asked the Mensheviks. When these 60 men were being sent away, a certain British officer, a lawyer and a woman under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuffed

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played the principal parts. The latter acted as interpreter and told the prisoners that they would be taken good care of by the Englishmen, which was proved by the fact that Gordon and Uloth took away all they had from them!

Before we went further into Sistan two men of our company were put on horseback under a strong escort and sent further into the mountains in order to be shot, as we afterwards learned. One of them was a rich Persian, who had made the Turkish government a present of 1,000,000 roubles for war purposes. He was called Alieff, the other was an Armenian called Arunoff.

On the way to Sistan we suffered very much from hunger. We stole from our drivers whenever we could - oats, onions and bread. Straved goats which were intended for our soup were carried with us on our cart. Three times the cart overturned and we nearly lost our lives because chained as we were, we could not jump out in time.

In Belutschistan I met a British officer who declared that my brother in Teheran was one of his best friends, but that he was forbidden to communicate with him. We drove across the Himalaya mountains and at last were released from our fetters in Delhi. We took a cold bath, received blankets and a few clothes. We arrived on the 14th November 1918 in the secret samp Novgong, where we were interned in barracks and surrounded by barbed wire and guards. Here we were cross-examined by a major and a captain. I wrote at once to Mr. Ringger, the Swiss consul in Bombay, and asked him to take steps in order to obtain my immediate release. A month later Dr. Rentdorff was released and went to Bombay where he reported to the Swiss Concul about me. Consul Ringger then asked permission from the British General Staff in Simla to see me at Novgong, which he obtained, but had received none of my letters. On March 13th, we were sent to Achmednager into the German prisoners camp. As I was without means Ringger telegraphed to the British Legation in Teheran asking my brother to send me money, and I promptly received £100. In the meantime Consul Ringger had obtained permission from Simla to send me home, and he took a first-class ticket to Genoa for my account on an Italian steamer.

under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuff

On the 5th July I left Achmednagar for Bombay, where I was received by the British Authorities. I was put into barracks and under strong escort dragged through the streets to the authorities. Consul Ringger was not informed until two days after my arrival. We were told that I could not leave by an Italian steamer for Genoa, but would have to go by an English boat to Suez - protests did not avail. Ringger brought me clothing and accompanied me to the steamer, but felt very concerned about the orders of the British Government. On the ship there were three Rusdians who had been expelled from Australia owing to bolshevistic and anarchistic propaganda. These men had an escort, whereas I was looked upon as being free.

After being on the water for 16 days we arrived at Porttewfik, and were received by the military control officer. I was considered one of the bolsheviks, my protests were not listened to, and under strong escort I was conducted with the bolsheviks into the Indian transit camp, where we were interned, together with five Russians, in tents and with a strong Indian guard. After protesting incesssantly I was informed on the 3rd day that I was free and could live at my own expense at an hotel. I left for Suez and went to the hotel. However the charge was £2 per day and as I had only taken £40 with me, which was given to me by Consul Ringger, and as I shared his presentiment that my stay might be a protracted one, there was nothing left for me to do but return to the transit camp and to share both happiness and sorrow with the bolsheviks. For a whole month I went every day to the M.C.O. at Porttewfik in order to negotiate for my release, which was to depend upon the General Staff at Cairo. I was not allowed to go to Cairo myself in order to present my own case, and the M.C.O. continued his lie for a whole month - that he was in communication with the General Staff. It was only in the third month when I declared to the officers that I should take my own life if I did not obtain my release, Colonel Haldane sent me with his adjutant at his own risk to Cairo, and my case was very energetically taken up by this young officer. At first the General Staff maintained that the prisoner Stump had been under the eyes of witnesses, we were handcuffed

sent 2½ months ago to Genoa, then they assured me that they had received no correspondence from the M.C.O. from Pörttewfik, in short I gained the impression I had not been kept back by a mistake, but intentionally.

My passport was put in order within four days and I was then allowed to travel home for my own account. As I had no means, and as I did not wish to lose time in order to wire to my brother asking him for money, I applied to the above named Colonel Haldane who very kindly advanced me £50. I then left by the first possible steamer for Genoa, and arrived at Geneva on October 4th.